

Prenatal care options

Throughout your pregnancy, you may be cared for by a family-practice doctor, obstetrician, or a combination of the two. The goal of your prenatal care is to monitor you and your baby so that problems can be identified and managed.

Your care during pregnancy

Early in pregnancy, you will need to think about who you would like to care for you during pregnancy, labor, and the postpartum period. You will also need to consider where you want to give birth since this will have an influence on your choice of care provider. The main options are outlined below, although these may vary depending on where you live. When you attend your first prenatal appointment at 8–12 weeks, you will be given information about the prenatal services you can access in your area. The medical checkups that are done during this appointment will also help establish the best choice for you prenatal care.

Types of prenatal care

The majority of your care will usually be provided by an ob/gyn. At your first appointment, they will outline the prenatal services you will receive.

Group medical practice With this type of care, you will see two or more doctors (typically ob/gyns and/or family practitioners throughout your pregnancy on a rotation basis. One of these doctors will be present at the hospital when you deliver.

Solo medical practice You'll have one doctor, and you will see them at every prenatal visit. They'll attend your birth at the hospital, unless they're unavailable and arrange for another doctor to be present for your delivery.

Combination practice With this type of care, you'll get to see both doctors and midwives. At least one ob/gyn and one nurse-midwife sees patients on a rotating basis. Depending on the practice, a midwife may be able to assist in delivery at the hospital. Expect a doctor to be present.

Maternity center-based practice If your pregnancy is low-risk, you can see certified nurse-midwives for most of your appointments throughout pregnancy. Ob/gyns are available for consultations as required. If you choose this option, you'll deliver your baby at the maternity or birthing center that is associated with the practice, unless complications arise, in which case your care would be transferred to the affiliated hospital.